

after its first performance in 1927.

“ A **creative artist** works on his **next composition** because he is **not satisfied** with his **previous one**. ”

DMITRI SHOSTAKOVICH, NEW YORK TIMES,
OCTOBER 25, 1959

He was also working on an opera, *The Nose*, and a Third Symphony; both premiered in 1930. *The Nose* in particular attracted criticism from the authorities—who misunderstood its satirical nature—and stinging reviews condemning its incomprehensible modernity. This response was a lesson to Shostakovich in how far he could go before incurring the wrath of the establishment, and the dangers he faced in his next major project, the opera *Lady Macbeth of the Mtsensk District*, completed in 1934. The opera was enthusiastically received by audiences as well as the authorities. But the good times were short-lived. Shostakovich’s marriage to Nina Varzar ended in divorce in 1935, but they remarried shortly after when Nina discovered she was pregnant (their daughter, Galina, was born in 1936 and a son, Maxim, in 1938).

In 1936, Shostakovich was advised to attend a performance of *Lady Macbeth of the Mtsensk District* at which Stalin would be present. It soon became clear to the terrified composer that Stalin disapproved of the opera, which was then slated in the official